

CONTACT	University of Pennsylvania Graduate School of Education 3700 Walnut St. Philadelphia, PA 19104	e-mail: sadeb@upenn.edu https://sade-bonilla.github.io ORCID  Google Scholar
ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS	Assistant Professor, University of Pennsylvania Faculty Research Director, Office of School & Community Engagement Faculty Affiliate, Consortium for Policy Research in Education Assistant Professor, University of Massachusetts Amherst Faculty Affiliate, Center for Student Success Research	2022–present 2024–present 2022–present 2019–2022 2019–2022
EDUCATION	Stanford University Ph.D., Economics of Education, 2019 M.A., Economics, 2017 Brown University A.M., Urban Education Policy, 2010 A.B., Public Policy & American Institutions, 2008 A.B., Education Studies: Policy Concentration, 2008	
PUBLICATIONS		
PEER-REVIEWED		
	10. Bonilla, S. & Sparks, D. (2026). Get a Skill, Get a Job, Get Ahead? Evaluating the Effects of Virginia’s Workforce-Targeted Free College Program. <i>Economics of Education Review</i> . 112, 102798. DOI:10.1016/j.econedurev.2026.102798 <i>Impact Factor (2025): 1.8</i>	
	9. Bisht, B., Bonilla, S. , Kim, H.E., & Penner, E.K. (2026). Cultural Relevance at Scale: The Effects of an Ethnic Studies Expansion on Academic Outcomes. <i>American Educational Research Journal</i> . <i>Impact Factor (2024): 3.6</i>	
	8. Sparks, D. & Bonilla, S. (2025). The Role of Policy Design in Free College Programs: Evidence from Virginia. <i>Education Finance and Policy</i> . DOI:10.1162/edfp.a.23.1-15. Supporting info: 9 pages) <i>Impact Factor (2024): 2.0</i>	
	7. Bonilla, S. & Thim, A. (2025). The Effects of At-Scale Career Pathway Investments on the Transition from High School to College. <i>Education Finance and Policy</i> , 20(4), 609-635. <i>Impact Factor (2024): 2.0</i>	
	6. Bonilla, S. , McDermott, K.A., & Gerstl-Pepin, C. (2022). The Politics of COVID-19 and Educational Inequities. <i>Peabody Journal of Education</i> , 97(3), 251256. (6 pages) <i>Impact Factor (2023): 0.835</i>	

5. Dougherty, S.M., Ecton, W.G., **Bonilla, S.**, & McGuinness, S. (2022). COVID-19 and Career Preparation. *Peabody Journal of Education*, 97(3), 326343. (18 pages)
Impact Factor (2023): 0.835
4. **Bonilla, S.**, Dee, T.S., & Penner, E.K. (2021). Ethnic Studies Increases Longer-run Academic Engagement and Attainment. *PNAS*, 118(37), 110. (10 pages; Supporting info: 10 pages)
Impact Factor (2024): 9.1
3. Tseng, A.S., **Bonilla, S.** & MacPherson, A. (2021). Fighting Bad Science in the Information Age. *Journal of Research in Science Teaching*, 58(8), 11521178. (Supporting info: 29 pages)
Impact Factor (2024): 4.5
2. **Bonilla, S.** (2020). The Dropout Effects of Career Pathways: Evidence from California. *Economics of Education Review*, 75, 101972, 1-20. (20 pages, Supporting info: 10 pages)
Impact Factor (2023): 1.8
1. **Bonilla, S.**, & Dee, T. (2020). The Effects of School Reform Under NCLB Waivers: Evidence From Focus Schools in Kentucky. *Education Finance and Policy*, 15(1), 75103. (29 pages; Online appendix: 11 pages)
Impact Factor (2024): 2.0

BOOK CHAPTERS

1. **Bonilla, S.**, Dougherty, S.M. & Ecton, W.J. (2025). Career and Technical Education: History, Theory, Evidence, and the Path Ahead. In Cohen-Vogel, L., Scott, J., & Youngs, P. (Eds). *Handbook of Education Policy Research*, 2nd Edition.

UNDER REVIEW

1. **Bonilla, S.**, Dee, T.S., & Pyne, J. (*Revise & Resubmit*). Culturally Relevant Education Discourages Enrollment Loss. *Educational Evaluation and Policy Analysis*.
2. **Bonilla, S.** & Minaya, V. (*Revise & Resubmit*). Affording to Stay: Experimental Evidence on a Cost-of-Living Grant in Community Colleges. [Pre-registered RCT: doi 10.17605/osf.io/p67cd]. *Education Finance and Policy*.
3. **Bonilla, S.** & Sparks, D. (*Revise & Resubmit*). Aligned Pathways, Unequal Earnings: Gendered Transitions from Community College to Work. *AERA Open*.
4. **Bonilla, S.** (*Revise & Resubmit*). Causal Evidence on High School Ethnic Studies and Civic Participation. *AERA Open*.

REPORTS

1. **Bonilla, S.** (2025). The distribution and allocation of teachers in the School District of Philadelphia: Findings and implications for equitable access to high-quality instruction.
2. **Bonilla, S.** (2021). Engagement and attainment: The longer-term causal effects of ethnic studies. Research Snapshot Brief, Student Experience Research Network.

3. **Bonilla, S.**, Carruthers, C.K. & Baker, D.J. (2020). Guidance and Supports for Students Moving into Postsecondary. Annenberg Institute for School Reform Covid-19 Briefs for State and District Policymakers.

WORKING PAPERS

- **Bonilla, S.**, & Minaya, V. (2025). Mental Health and Basic Needs as Barriers to Persistence and Credit Accumulation in Community Colleges. Available as EdWorking Paper 24-925: <https://doi.org/10.26300/0cw6-fe07>
- **Bonilla, S.**, Bennett, E., & Chan, M. (2026). Impacts of Need-Based Financial Aid for Non-Tuition Expenses. [Pre-registered study].

FUNDED RESEARCH

EXTERNAL AWARDS	Arnold Ventures \$325,248 (PI)	2026–2028
	<i>Funding Pathways to Success: The Policy Impact of Tuition-Free Dual Enrollment on Attainment and Workforce Preparation</i>	
	Neubauer Family Foundation \$1,783,835 (Co-PI)	2025–2029
	<i>Evaluation of the Algebra I Fellowship</i> in partnership with the School District of Philadelphia	
	Spencer Foundation \$49,854 (PI)	2025–2026
	<i>The Causal Effect of Ethnic Studies on Civic Participation and Postsecondary Attainment</i>	
	Lumina Foundation \$48,862 (co-PI)	2025–2026
	<i>Last Mile Funding for the G3 Evaluation</i>	
	Institute for Education Sciences \$2,999,746 [\$497,724 subaward] (Co-PI)	2022–2027
	<i>Strengthening Virginia’s Pandemic Recovery Efforts: Providing High-Quality Community College Workforce Education to Underserved Adults</i>	
	Note: Canceled by the Department of Education on March 7, 2025 as part of Title VI enforcement action against Columbia University (prime) and reinstated August 1, 2026	
	Arnold Ventures \$360,537 (PI)	2022–2026
	<i>Cost-of-Living Grant Pilot on Community College Student Success</i>	
	William & Flora Hewlett Foundation \$620,000 [\$32,840 subaward] (Co-PI)	2021–2024
	<i>Centering Student Voice to Understand the Influence of Ethnic Studies Courses on Students Academic, Behavioral, and Social-Emotional Outcomes: A Cross-Case Mixed Methods Collaboration</i>	
	Mindset Scholars Network \$120,000 (Co-PI)	2019–2020
	<i>The Longer-term Effects of Ethnic Studies</i>	
	Spencer Foundation/NAEd \$27,500 (Dissertation Fellow)	2018–2019

The Effects of Articulated Career Pathway Reforms for High School Students

INTERNAL AWARDS	Bridge Funding Program University of Pennsylvania \$13,924 (PI) <i>Support to sustain postdoctoral mentorship and research continuity following federal funding disruption.</i>	2025–2026
	Grants for Faculty Mentoring Undergraduate Research \$8,000 (PI) <i>Evaluation of a Cost-of-Living Grant Pilot on Community College & The distribution and allocation of teachers in the School District of Philadelphia</i>	2023–2024
	Penn Undergraduate Research Mentoring Program (PURM) \$10,000 <i>Strengthening Virginia's Workforce Pandemic Recovery Efforts</i>	2022–2023
UMASS AMHERST	Public Service Endowment Grant UMass Amherst \$14,459 <i>Bridging the Gap to College During Covid-19</i>	2021–2022
	Faculty Research Grant/Healey Grant UMass Amherst \$19,179 <i>The Causal Effects of Career Pathways on Educational Attainment</i>	2021–2022
HONORS & AWARDS	Postsecondary Education & Economics Research (PEER) Center <i>Summer Scholar (selected participant)</i>	2026
	Public Engagement Project, UMass Amherst <i>Fellowship recipient: \$1,000</i>	2021–2022
	ADVANCE Mutual Mentoring Grant, UMass Amherst <i>Award recipient: \$5,500</i>	2021–2022
	Association for Education Finance & Policy <i>Early Career Program Participant</i>	2021–2022
	Faculty Success Fellows Program, UMass Amherst <i>Fellowship recipient: \$2,950</i>	2020–2021
	Outstanding Predoctoral Award, Institute for Education Sciences (IES) <i>Award recipient</i>	2019
	Emerging Education Policy Scholar <i>Fellowship recipient</i>	2018–2019
	UC Presidents Postdoctoral Fellowship Program <i>Postdoctoral Fellow Semi-finalist</i>	2018
	Karr Family Fellowship Program <i>Fellowship recipient</i>	2016–2018
	APPAM Equity and Inclusion Fellowship <i>Fellowship recipient</i>	2016
	Predoectional Training Program, Institute of Educational Sciences (IES)	2013–2016

Pre-doctoral Fellow

Fulbright Fellowship, U.S. Department of State
Fellow, Chile 2009

PRESENTATIONS

INVITED	University of Delaware (<i>invited</i>)	2026
TALKS	Pontificia Universidad Catolica de Chile (<i>invited</i>)	
	New America (<i>policy think tank</i>)	
	Arnold Ventures	
	Southern Methodist University	
	Princeton University	2025
	Texas A&M University	
	School District of Philadelphia	
	MA Commission on Higher Education Quality & Affordability	2024
	U.S. Department of Education	
	Boston University	
	Virginia Community College System	
	University of Wisconsin–Madison	
	Harvard Graduate School of Education	
	Massachusetts Commission of Higher Education	2023
	RAND Corporation	
	Brown University	
	Brookings Institute	
	San Diego State University	2022
	University of Chicago	
	CALDER (Center for Analysis of Longitudinal Data in Education Research)	
	University of Pennsylvania	2021
	D.C. State Board of Education	
	Espacio Publico Chile	
	SUNY Albany	
	Council of Chief State School Officers (CCSSO)	
	Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation	
	San Francisco Unified School District	
	Santa Clara University	
	Holyoke Public Schools (MA)	
	Urban Institute	2020
	Mindset Scholars Network	
	Montana State University	2019

University of Washington, Seattle
 Saint Louis University
 University of Florida
 University of Massachusetts Amherst

2018

PEER-
 REVIEWED

Higher Education Finance Research Conference, Federal Reserve Bank of Philadelphia (Philadelphia, PA, 2026); American Educational Research Association Annual Meeting (Los Angeles, 2026); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Chicago, 2026); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Chicago, 2026); Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management, Fall Conference (Seattle, 2025); American Educational Research Association Annual Meeting (Denver, 2025); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Washington D.C., 2025); Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management, Fall Conference (National Harbor, 2024); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Baltimore, 2024); Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management, Fall Conference (Atlanta, 2023); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Denver, 2023); Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management, Fall Conference (Washington D.C., 2022); American Educational Research Association Annual Meeting (San Diego, 2022); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Denver, 2022); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Virtual, 2021); Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management, Fall Conference (Virtual, 2020); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Virtual, 2020); Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management, Fall Conference (Denver, 2019); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Kansas City, 2019); Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management, Fall Conference (Washington D.C., 2016); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Washington D.C., 2016); Graduate School of Education (Stanford, CA, 2016); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (San Antonio, TX, 2014); American Educational Research Association Annual Meeting (San Francisco, CA, 2013); Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management, Fall Conference (Baltimore, MD, 2012)

TEACHING

University of Pennsylvania

Education Policy Foundations (graduate)	2026
Economic Perspectives on Higher Education Policy (masters)	2026
Inquiry Fundamentals for Education Policy (masters)	2025–2026
Education Policy Research Practicum (masters)	2023–2025
Advanced Causal Inference Research and Reporting (doctoral)	2022, 2023

University of Massachusetts Amherst	
Economics of Education (graduate)	2020, 2021
Economics of Education (undergraduate)	2021
Higher Education Policy (graduate)	2019–2021
Causal Inference in Educational Research (graduate)	2021

ADVISING

Doctoral Advising

Primary Advisor:

Evan Bennett (Penn GSE, Ph.D. in-progress)

Jennifer Benavides (Penn GSE Ed.D., Chair, in-progress)

Committee Member:

Margot Todman-Mack (Penn GSE Ed.D., defended 5/2025)

Susan E. Thompson (Penn GSE Ed.D., defended 5/2023)

Catherine Park (UMass Amherst Ph.D., defended 4/2023)

Jonathon Montoya (UC Irvine Ph.D., defended 8/2022)

Postdoctoral Advising

Brittany Vasquez, Ph.D.

Daniel Sparks, Ph.D. [Placement: University of Arkansas]

Undergraduate Advising

Samantha Salcedo (Penn SAS, Media & Urban Studies, exp. 2025)

Pre-doctoral Diversity Fellow AEFP, 2024

Dedee Gauthikonda (Penn SAS, Economics, exp. 2026)

Equity & Inclusion Fellow APPAM, 2023

Michael Fuentes (Penn SAS, Economics, exp. 2026)

Equity & Inclusion Fellow APPAM, 2023

Allan Lee (Penn SAS, Economics 2023)

Pre-doctoral Diversity Fellow AEFP 2023

SERVICE

University of Pennsylvania

Executive Committee (School) 2025–2026

Member

Ad Hoc Committee on Community Engaged Scholarship 2024–2026

Member

Policy, Organizations, Leadership & Systems Doctoral Seminar 2022–2023

Co-Instructor

Education Policy Doctoral Admissions 2023, 2024

Committee Member

Pre-tenure Faculty Writing and Accountability Group 2022–present

Co-organizer and Member

Causal Inference Working Groups <i>Member</i>	2022-2023
<i>University of Massachusetts Amherst</i>	
Department Academic Matters Committee (Department) <i>Committee Member</i>	2021–2022
Public Service Endowment Grants Reviewer (University) <i>Ad-hoc Reviewer</i>	Spring 2020
Scholarship Selection Committee (College) <i>Committee Member</i>	Spring 2020
AQAD Undergraduate Education Committee (Department) <i>Committee Member</i>	Spring 2020
Ph.D. Admissions (Department) <i>Committee Member</i>	2019–2020
M.Ed/MPPA Admissions (Department) <i>Committee Member</i>	2020–2021

REFEREE SERVICE

Reviewer for Journals

Journal for Research on Educational Effectiveness; Journal of Policy Analysis and Management; Economics of Education Review; Education Finance and Policy; Educational Evaluation and Policy Analysis; American Education Research Journal; AERA Open; Education Researcher; Journal of Labor Economics; Journal of Higher Education.

Editorial Board Member:

<i>Educational Evaluation and Policy Analysis</i>	2025 – present
<i>AERA Open</i>	2020 – 2021

PROFESSIONAL ASSOCIATIONS

Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM)

Co-Chair, Education Section	2024, 2025
Reviewer, Education Section	2022– 2025
Reviewer, Equity & Inclusion Fellowship	2023

Association for Education Finance and Policy (AEFP)

Reviewer, Spring Conference	2023– 2026
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American Educational Research Association (AERA)

Reviewer, Spring Conference	2023
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MEDIA MENTIONS

Harkay, J. (2026, July 14). Can ethnic studies bridge the achievement gap? San Francisco program shows gains. The 74 Million.

Johnson, G. (2026, July 10). Taking ethnic studies courses increases academic performance. Penn Today.

Tribune News Report (2026, May 1). New study finds ethnic studies linked to higher GPAs for Black, Latino students. Philadelphia Tribune

Sleeter, C. (2025, April 22) California leaders must keep their promise by funding ethnic studies. EdSource

Sellery, K. (2024, Winter). Bridging the gap: How career technical education unites job training and academics. California Schools.

Strauss, V. (2023, June 8) What it really takes to help students succeed. Washington Post.

Rebar, S. (2023, February 3) Sade Bonilla studies how to engage high school students. Penn GSE News.

Smith, E. (2023, February 3). Examining college enrollment gaps: A discussion with leading scholars. Brookings Institute.

Wiener, R. & Lopez, F. (2022, March 29). Ignoring racism in schools actually increases prejudice. Education Week.

Lunn, B. (2022, February 22). IES honors Sade Bonilla as 2019 Outstanding Predoctoral Fellow. Inside IES Research.

Saldaña, C. (2021, October 19). National Education Policy Center Talks Education. NEPC.

Mays, M. (2021, October 14). California students will have to take ethnic studies to get a diploma. Politico.

Speakman, K. (2021, October 8) California requires ethnic studies for high school students. Forbes.

Fensterwalk, J. (2021, September 7) Research finds ethnic studies in San Francisco had enduring impact. EdSource.

Spector, C. (2019, May 15). Schools that received state funds to expand career training programs saw lower dropout rates, Stanford researcher finds. Stanford.